

Lesson 3: “I Had Seen a Vision” ([Joseph Smith—History 1:1-26](#); [Our Heritage pp. 1-4](#))

Purpose: To strengthen our testimonies of the First Vision and of Joseph Smith’s calling as the prophet through whom God restored the fullness of the gospel to the earth.

Online video: [A Search for the Truth](#) tells of Wilford Woodruff’s experience with Robert Mason who counseled him to look for a church with apostles and prophets and priesthood authority. As you watch this video look Wilford Woodruff’s four criteria of the true church: 1) Prophets and Apostles, 2) priesthood authority, 3) correct doctrine, and 4) saving ordinances.

1. After the Apostasy, God prepared the way for the Restoration.

“After Jesus Christ was crucified, His Apostles presided over the Church. But soon persecution, divisions, and apostasy increased. Within a few decades, there was a falling away from the Church, as the Apostles had prophesied.” (*Lesson Manual*) (See [2 Thess. 2:1-3](#); [Acts 20:28-30](#); [2 Timothy 4:3-4](#)). †1. President Hugh B. Brown What are some of the consequences of the Great Apostasy?

• See D&C 1:15-16; JS—History 1: 8-13, 19, 21

“The darkness of the Apostasy lasted many centuries. However, God had foreseen this and planned for the restoration of the gospel in the latter days. Elder Bruce R. McConkie ... taught that preparation for restoring the gospel began centuries before the First Vision ...” (*Lesson Manual*)

Before Joseph Smith was born, what events helped prepare the way for the restoration of the gospel?

†2. Historical Events Preparing us for the Gospel †3. Historical Setting at the time of Joseph Smith’s Birth

2. God prepared Joseph Smith to be the prophet of the Restoration.

“God provided a man to be the prophet of the restoration.” (*Lesson Manual*) †4. Preparation of Joseph Smith

How did Joseph’s family heritage prepare him for his mission as prophet of the Restoration?

Regarding his leg operation, What can we learn about young Joseph’s character?

How could trials and afflictions prepare him for his mission?

When the family moved to Palmyra, New York, how did the religious fervor there prepare him?

How did scripture study help Joseph resolve his confusion?

How have the scriptures helped you in times of need or confusion?

3. The First Vision ushered in the restoration of the gospel.

- JS—History 1:14 Why is private vocal prayer often helpful?
- JS—History 1:15 What happened as Joseph Smith began to pray?
- JS—History 1:16-17 How was Joseph Smith delivered from this powerful darkness?

What are some possible meanings of this experience for us?

- JS—History 1:18-19 What reasons did Christ give that Joseph Smith should not join any church?

4. Many truths were revealed in the First Vision.

†5. President Gordon B. Hinckley

What are some of the truths we can learn from the First Vision? †6. President David O. McKay

President Ezra Taft Benson:

“The appearance of God the Father and his Son Jesus Christ to the boy prophet is the greatest event that has occurred in this world since the resurrection of the Master” (“[Life is Eternal](#),” *Ensign*, June 1971, 34).

What are some reasons it is important for each of us to have a testimony of the First Vision?

How has a testimony of the First Vision blessed your life?

Next Week: Lesson 4: “Remember the New Covenant, ... the Book of Mormon; See [L4 Study Guide](#). † •
(You can download a free LDS Institute Manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).)

†1. **President Hugh B. Brown:** “The Church of England and other Protestant churches frankly admit the fact of the Apostasy. Our question is, if the ‘Mother Church’ was without divine authority or spiritual power, how could her children derive from her the right to officiate in the things of God?” (*The Abundant Life*, 97)

†2. Historical Events preparing us for the Gospel:

a. The Renaissance: Inventions such as the printing press emerged giving people greater personal access to the scriptures. **Elder James E. Talmage** said the Renaissance was a “development predetermined in the mind of God to illumine the benighted minds of men in preparation for the restoration of the gospel of Jesus Christ, which was appointed to be accomplished some centuries later” (*Jesus the Christ*, 3rd ed. [1916], 749).

b. Reformers such as John Wycliffe and Martin Luther challenged existing religious dogmas and churches. **Elder M. Russell Ballard** said the reformers “were inspired to create a religious climate in which God could restore lost truths and priesthood authority” (“[Restored Truth](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1994, 66).

c. Columbus discovered America ([1 Ne. 13:12-19](#)).

d. The Constitution of the United States was established, guaranteeing religious freedom in America (see [D&C 101:77-80](#)). **Elder M. Russell Ballard** said, “God inspired the earlier explorers and colonizers of America and the framers of the Constitution of the United States to develop a land and governing principles to which the gospel could be restored” (“[Restored Truth](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 1994, 66). (*Lesson Manual*)

†3. Historical Setting at the time of Joseph Smith’s Birth:

1781 – Cornwallis surrendered at Yorktown
1783 – End of the Revolutionary War. The Treaty of Paris recognized the new United States.
1787 – Sep. 17: U.S. Constitution adopted at Convention
1789 – Mar. 4: U.S. Constitution goes into effect.
1803 Louisiana Purchase
[1805 Year of Joseph Smith’s birth](#)
Mar. 4: Thomas Jefferson sworn in for second term
May 26: Lewis & Clark first see Rocky Mountains
Jun. 13: Lewis & Clark first see Great Falls, Missouri
Oct. 21: Battle of Trafalgar – Lord Nelson defeats French and Spanish fleets
Nov. 7: Lewis & Clark first sees the Pacific Ocean
Nov. 11: Napoleonic Wars
Nov. 19: Lewis & Clark arrive at the Pacific Ocean
Dec. 3: End of the French Republic calendar. France returns to the Gregorian calendar.
Dec. 23: Joseph Smith is born.
(References: *Atlas of World History*, 127; Wikipedia: [1805 in the United States](#); HistoryOrb.com “[Historical Events for Year 1805](#)”.)

†4. Preparation of Joseph Smith:

Joseph’s family helped prepare him

“His parents and grandparents were religious, patriotic, educationally minded, and of strong moral convictions. His paternal grandfather, Asael Smith, stated years before Joseph was born, ‘It has been borne in upon my soul that one of my descendants will promulgate a work to revolutionize the world of religious faith’” (in Joseph Fielding Smith, *Essentials in Church History*, 27th ed. [1974], 25)...

“Both of Joseph’s parents had profound religious experiences. Joseph Sr. had several dreams that gave him assurances that he would enjoy the blessings of the true gospel of Jesus Christ (see Lucy Mack Smith, *History of Joseph Smith*, ed. Preston Nibley [1958], 47-50, 64-66)... **Adversity helped prepare him**

“... When he was seven years old, he became gravely ill with an infection in his leg. (See *Our Heritage*, pages 1-2)

The religious atmosphere at Palmyra prepared him

“When Joseph was about 10 years old, three years of crop failures in Vermont left the Smith family in serious financial difficulty. After much deliberation, the family moved to the area of Palmyra, New York, ... At the time, there was great religious excitement and confusion in western New York, with many churches contending for converts.” (*Lesson Manual*)

†5. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “I submit that in the few minutes that Joseph Smith was with the Father and the Son, he learned more of the nature of God the Eternal Father and the risen Lord than all the learned minds in all their discussions through all centuries of time.” (*Church News*, 24 Oct. 1998, 6).

†6. **President David O. McKay** testified that the First Vision “answers all the [questions] regarding God and his divine personality... His relation to his children is clear. His interest in humanity through authority delegated to man is apparent. The future of the work is assured. These and other glorious truths are clarified by that glorious vision” (*Gospel Ideals* [1954], 85).

Recommended Reading:

President Gordon B. Hinckley, “[What Hath God Wrought through His Servant Joseph!](#)” *Ensign*, Jan. 1997, 2.
President Gordon B. Hinckley, “[Four Cornerstones of Faith](#),” *Ensign*, Feb. 2004, 2-7.
Gerrit Dirkmaat, Church History Department, “[Great and Marvelous are the Revelations of God](#),” *Ensign*, Jan. 2013, 44-49.

Visit www.stephenmbird.com/library/gospel-doctrine †

Further Enrichment Resources:

JS—History 1:19. “They deny the power thereof.”
The Apostasy and Restoration

Stephen Robinson: “The Greek word *apostasia* (apostasy, falling away) means *rebellion* or *revolution*. It conveys the sense of an internal takeover by factions hostile to the intentions of the previous leaders. I personally prefer the translation *mutiny*, as it suggests that unauthorized members commandeer a ship and take it where the ship is not supposed to go. Since early Christians often thought of the church as a ship, I think *mutiny* conveys the sense of what Paul and others mean by the term *apostasia*. (See 2 Thes. 2:3). ([“Warring against the Saints of God,”](#) *Ensign*, Jan 1988, 34)

Beverly A. Pitts, the wife of Mission President Neil E. Pitts (Utah Provo Mission), said, “President Pitts and I are converts. He was showering and received an overwhelming spirit telling him he needed to be baptized.”

When he told her, she reminded him he’d been baptized in the Presbyterian church.

He said, “[I know, but for some reason it doesn’t count.](#)”

So he began to learn about other churches. Two sisters knocked at the door and he said, “I’ve been looking for you.”

They sat down and he said, “Can you tell me in a few sentences why I should listen to you?”

One sister said, “I can tell you in one word, ‘[Authority](#)’.”

As the sisters taught, Sister Pitts started to cry and her husband asked, “What’s the matter? Why are you crying?”

She said, “I know what they’re teaching is true.”

He said, “I know it’s true too.”

Following Sister Pitts talk; **President Pitt** went to the speakers stand and added more to the story.

He said, “As we were getting ready to be baptized I called my brother and said, ‘I think you should know we’re getting baptized.’”

His brother said, “No way! We’re getting baptized too.”

He told the young men in the audience, “[You will see miracles and come home rock solid.](#)”

His daughter said, “Dad, I *don’t want* to serve a mission.”

He said, “You don’t have to.”

“Dad ...” She and her father repeated this three times.

Then she said, “*But I have to.* I received a witness. I’ve been called.”

([“The Way of the Disciple,”](#) *Ensign*, May 2009, 77 (75-78)). (My notes of Grove Creek Stake Conference and Father’s Day, Sunday, June 19, 2011.)

Jing-juan Chen, Taiwan: “When I decided to get baptized, it was because some of my troubles were resolved while I was taking the discussions. It wasn’t because I had prayed and received a testimony that the Book of Mormon was true or that Joseph Smith saw Heavenly Father and his Son, Jesus Christ. The missionaries had invited me to pray about these things, but I never did. I simply believed what the missionaries had taught me.

“Three years after my baptism, a sister stood at the chapel podium and shared her testimony of the Book of Mormon and Joseph Smith. She asked everyone to ponder this question: “Have we truly prayed about the truthfulness of the Book of Mormon and about the experience Joseph Smith had?” This question hit me hard, and I thought to myself, “I have never prayed about these things, but I should and I will.”

“I was motivated to take action because my faith at the time was weak and my testimony of the scriptures was shallow. That night I prayed to my Father about Joseph Smith and the truthfulness of the Book of Mormon.

[“I didn’t feel anything the first time I prayed, nor the second time. Not to be discouraged, I opened the scriptures to Joseph Smith—History 1:14-17, where it describes how Joseph went to the grove to have a personal prayer:](#)

[“I saw a pillar of light exactly over my head, above the brightness of the sun, which descended gradually until it fell upon me.”](#)

[“It no sooner appeared than I found myself delivered.... When the light rested upon me I saw two Personages.”](#)

[“As I read the words, I started shaking as if an electric current had gone through my whole body. Instantly I knew that Joseph Smith had indeed seen Heavenly Father and His Beloved Son, Jesus Christ. I knew that we had the Book of Mormon because God had translated it through His prophet.](#)

[“I’m grateful that Heavenly Father granted me this witness of the truthfulness of the First Vision. I realized that if the gospel had not been restored, I would not have known my Redeemer. I know the fullness of the gospel is true, and I know I will receive God’s promises if I endure faithfully to the end.”](#) (“Latter-day Saint Voices: [My First Prayer about the First Vision](#),” Jing-juan Chen, Taiwan, *Ensign*, Jan. 2013, 71.)

Links for further information and study:

[Joel's Monastery, D&C lesson 3](#) "I Had Seen a Vision" includes some very fine quotes about the apostasy.

Ted Gibbons: "If you want to uncover the truth, you will need a S.P.A.D.E.

S = Study:

Notice how the following words from Joseph's account of the first vision (Joseph Smith—History) indicate his efforts to learn the truth by study.

- "I attended their several meetings" (1:8)
- "I was unable to come to any certain conclusion" (1:8)
- "I was one day reading the epistle of James" (1:11)
- "I reflected on it again and again" (1:12)
- "At length I came to the conclusion" (1:13)

P = Ponder:

- "My mind was called up to serious reflection" (1:8)
- "I often said to myself: What is to be done" (1:10)
- "Who of all these parties is right?" (1:10)
- "It was impossible ... to come to any certain conclusion" (1:8)

A = Alone:

- "I retired to the woods" (1:14)
- "... finding myself alone" (1:15)

The instruction to seek the Lord in a place free from distractions has been given often. See Alma 34:26-27; Matt. 14:23; Matt. 6:6; Alma 33:7.

D = Desires:

- "I kneeled down and began to offer up the desires of my heart to God" (1:15)
- In the area of desires, see 3 Ne. 19:24; 1 Ne. 2:16; Enos 1:12; Ether 3:2.

E = Exertion

- "But exerting all my powers to call upon God" (1:16)
 - "Just at this moment of greatest alarm" (1:16)"
- ([Ted L. Gibbons](#), DCL3 "I Had Seen A Vision")

President Wilford Woodruff "told of a meeting in which the Prophet Joseph Smith prophesied of the Church's growth. The meeting was in 'a small house, perhaps 14 feet square. But it held the whole of the Priesthood of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints who were then in the town of Kirtland, and who had gathered together to go off in Zion's camp.' After several of the men had borne their testimonies of the work, the Prophet said:

"Brethren I have been very much edified and instructed in your testimonies here tonight, but I want to say to you before the Lord, that you know no more concerning the destinies of this Church and kingdom than a babe upon its mother's lap. You don't comprehend it.... [It is only a little handful of priesthood you see here tonight, but this Church will fill North and South](#)

[America—it will fill the world](#)" (Conference Report, Apr. 1898, 57 as cited in D&C Lesson 9: "[The Only True and Living Church](#)" Go to the Conclusion and read the second and third paragraphs beginning with: President Wilford Woodruff told of a meeting.)

Nancy Jensen D&C L3 "[I Had Seen a Vision](#)" Planting, growing, nurturing black bamboo seeds is compared to preparing the world for the seeds of the gospel. It's a beautiful analogy. She also told more stories of miraculous miracles in Wilford Woodruff's preparation for the gospel. She also related the story of Wilford Woodruff's missionary, Zera Pulsipher, and of his preparation for the gospel and of his conversion. He saw a vision while praying in his barn. How will we prepare our children?

Nancy also links to a blogger's experience in China who was taught some of these things when visiting some black bamboo fields. His name was Jim Cecil and his post is entitled "[A Story of 'Black' Bamboo](#)".

Lenet Read at Scriptural Insights Lenet H. Read [D&C 3 I Had Seen a Vision](#) reveals the miracle of Joseph Smith's bone operation. She also tells the story of Dr. Robert Millet's conversion while on his mission.

Le Roy S. Wirthlin, "[Discovery: Joseph Smith's Surgeon](#)," *Ensign*, Mar. 1978 is the source for Lenet Read's story and there are some excellent insights here at the original article that can help us understand how God made the miracle of this operation for Joseph Smith, His prophet of the Dispensation of the Fullness of Times.

Elder D. Todd Christofferson: "I'm glad that Heavenly Father didn't respond to me that night in Palmyra. I might have thought that you have to be in a special place to get an answer to prayer or to gain a testimony. But you don't have to make a pilgrimage to Palmyra to know that Joseph Smith was a prophet or that the Book of Mormon is true. You don't have to go to Jerusalem to know that Jesus is the Christ. If Heavenly Father found me in Somerset, New Jersey, He can answer the prayers of anybody, anywhere in the world. He knows us intimately, and He can answer us whatever our place or circumstances." (Quentin L. Cook, "[Elder D. Todd Christofferson: Prepared to Serve the Lord](#)," *Ensign*, Aug 2008, 10-15)

Kevin Hinckley gives a "[Combined First Vision in MS Doc format](#)". To get a copy from the original website, go to [www.ldsgospeldoctrine.net](#). In the left column click on "2013 D&C". Then click on "(3) I Had Seen a Vision JS-H 1:1-26". Then click on the second Kevin Hinckley link.